MIL-A-3908C

7 March 1969
SUPERSEDING
MIL-A-003908B(GL)
22 January 1968 and
MIL-A-3908A
12 November 1965

MILITARY SPECIFICATION

AUGERS, POSTHOLE, HAND

This specification is mandatory for use by all Departments and Agencies of the Department of Defense.

* 1. SCOPE

1.1 Scope.- This specification covers hand-held posthole augers.

1.2 Classification.- The posthole augers shall be of the following types, classes, and sizes, as specified (see 6.2):

Type I - Telescoping stem

Class 1 - Nonadjustable bit - 6 inch.
Class 2 - Adjustable bit - 8 to 14 inches.

Type II - Nontelescoping stem, and nonadjustable bit.

Size 1 - 2 inch.
Size 2 - 4 inch.
Size 3 - 6 inch.
Size 4 - 8 inch.

2. APPLICABLE DOCUMENTS

2.1 The following documents, of the issue in effect on date of invitation for bids or request for proposal, form a part of the specification to the extent specified herein:

SPECIFICATIONS

FEDERAL

QQ-I-666 - Iron Castings, Malleable.
QQ-S-634 - Steel, Bar, Carbon, Cold Finished, (Standard Quality).
TT-E-485 - Enamel, Semi-Gloss, Rust Inhibiting.
WW-P-406 - Pipe, Steel (Seamless and Welded) (For Ordinary Use).

PSC 5120

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-16T22:00Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

MILITARY

MIL-B-857 - Bolts, Nuts, and Studs.
MIL-H-15424 - Hand Tools, Packaging Of.

STANDARD

MILITARY

MIL-STD-105 - Sampling Procedures and Tables for Inspection by Attributes.

(Copies of specifications and standards required by suppliers in connection with specific procurement functions should be obtained from the procuring activity or as directed by the contracting officer.)

2.2 Other publications.- The following documents form a part of this specification to the extent specified herein. Unless otherwise indicated, the issue in effect on date of invitation for bids or request for proposal shall apply.

NATIONAL BUREAU OF STANDARDS

Handbook H28 - Screw-Thread Standards for Federal Services

(Application for copies should be addressed to the Superintendent of Documents, Government Printing Office, Washington, D.C. 20402.)

AMERICAN SOCIETY FOR TESTING AND MATERIALS (ASTM)

D2016-62 Standard Methods of Test for Moisture Content of Wood
E18-65 Methods of Test for Rockwell Hardness and Rockwell Superficial Hardness of Metallic Materials.

(Application for copies should be addressed to the American Society for Testing and Materials, 1916 Race St., Philadelphia, Pa. 19103.)

(Technical society and technical association specifications and standards are generally available for reference from libraries. They are also distributed among technical groups and using Federal agencies.)

3. REQUIREMENTS

3.1 First article.- When specified (see 6.2), before production is commenced, a sample of the applicable end item shall be submitted or made available to the contracting officer or his authorized representative for approval in accordance with 4.2. The approval of the preproduction sample authorizes the commencement of production, but does not relieve the supplier

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-16T22:00Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

of responsibility for compliance with all applicable provisions of this specification. The preproduction sample shall be manufactured in the same facilities to be used for the manufacture of the production items.

3.2 Standard products.- Augers shall be the manufacturer's standard product except for any modification specified herein.

* 3.2.1 Illustrations.- The illustrations shown as figures 1 through 3 are for convenience of identification, and are not intended to preclude the procurement of augers otherwise in compliance with this specification.

3.3 Material.- Material not definitely specified shall be in accordance with the manufacturer's standard practice.

3.3.1 Hardwood handles.- The handles shall be straight-grained, sound, thoroughly seasoned ash, maple, or hickory. Moisture content shall not exceed 12 percent when examined in accordance with 4.3.1.1.

3.3.2 Malleable iron castings.- Malleable iron castings shall conform to grade I or II of QQ-I-666.

3.3.3 Steel pipe.- Steel pipe shall conform to weight A, class 1 of WW-P-406 except that hydrostatic tests shall not apply.

* 3.3.4 Steel bar.- Steel bar shall conform to QQ-S-634 as specified in table I.

TABLE I.- Steel bar

Type	Class	Component(s)	Steel No.	Condition
I	1	Telescoping bars	1045	Cold drawn
I	1 or 2	Locking pin(s)	1010 or 1015	Cold drawn
I	2	Telescoping bars	1045	Cold drawn

* 3.3.5 Blade steel.- Carbon steel for the blades shall have a carbon content of 0.66 to 0.80 percent, and shall have a hardness within the range of Rockwell C30 to C40 inclusive (see 4.3.1.2 and 4.3.1.3).

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-16T22:00Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

3.3.6 Bolts.- Bolts and nuts shall conform to MIL-B-857, grade 1 steel as follows:

(a) Bolts - Type IV

(b) Nuts - Type I

* 3.3.7 Spring wire.- When applicable, coiled springs shall be made from high quality carbon spring steel and shall be drawn or heat-treated to a hardness of Rockwell C30 to C36 inclusive (see 4.3 1.3).

3.4 Design and construction.-

3.4.1 Type I auger.- The type I auger shall be of the telescoping stem design, capable of being extended to an additional length of at least 90 percent of the nonextended length with a maximum fixed position interval of 7 inches. A self-positioning, positive locking mechanism shall be provided for securing the stem in its extended position. The outer fixed stem shall be 1-inch pipe size by 44 inches long (see 3.3.3). The inner telescoping stem shall be constructed from 3/4-inch round corner steel bar (see 3.3.4). Blades shall be made of not less than 0.080 inch thick steel (see 3.3.5).

3.4.1.1 Class 1.- The class 1 auger shall have a nonadjustable 6 inch bit (see figure 1).

3.4.1.2 Class 2.- The class 2 auger shall have an adjustable 8 inch to 14 inch bit with a maximum fixed position interval of 1 inch (see figure 2). The class 2 auger shall be capable of producing a hole having a nominal depth of 8 feet, 3 inches when tested in accordance with 4.4.1.

3.4.2 Type II auger.- The type II auger shall be similar to the type I, class 1 auger except that the stem shall be nonadjustable, 3/4-inch diameter by 33-inch long i.e.: only the outer stem, as described in 3.4.1, shall be provided (see figure 3). This type shall be furnished with a bit size as specified in accordance with 1.2. Sizes 3 and 4 shall be designed to permit attachment of an extension (see 3.4.2.1).

3.4.2.1 Stem extension (for sizes 3 and 4).- When specified (see 6.2), one or more additional extensions for the stem shall be furnished. These extensions shall consist of 3/4 inch pipe size by 48 inch lengths of standard steel pipe, threaded both ends to fit as stem extensions, and with one coupling for each extension.

* 3.4.3 Handles.- Type I and type II handles (see 3.3.1) shall have a minimum diameter of 1 inch, with a minimum length of 30 inches for type I and 22-inches for the type II auger, and shall be removable from the stem.

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-16T22:00Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

3.4.4 Fastening devices.- All nuts, bolts, pins, and similar parts shall be installed with adequate means for preventing loosening or becoming out of adjustment. All fastening devices subject to removal or adjustment shall not be swaged, peened, staked or otherwise permanently deformed.

3.4.5 Threaded parts.- Threads shall comply with Handbook H28.

3.5 Finish.- The auger shall be thoroughly cleaned of all rust, grease, and dirt, and given one coat of enamel conforming to TT-E-485. Painted surfaces shall be free from blisters and embedded foreign matter.

3.6 Marking for identification.- Augers shall be marked with the manufacturers' name or readily identifiable trademark.

3.7 Workmanship.- All burrs and sharp edges shall be removed; parts shall operate without any binding or stiffness; handles shall be free of splinters and knots.

3.7.1 Forgings.- Forgings shall be free from scale, inclosures, cold shuts, mismatching and other similar defects that may affect the structural strength of the forgings involved.

4. QUALITY ASSURANCE PROVISIONS

4.1 Responsibility for inspection.- Unless otherwise specified in the contract or purchase order, the supplier is responsible for the performance of all inspection requirements as specified herein. Except as otherwise specified in the contract or order, the supplier may use his own or any other facilities suitable for the performance of the inspection requirements specified herein, unless disapproved by the Government. The Government reserves the right to perform any of the inspections set forth in the specification where such inspections are deemed necessary to assure supplies and services conform to prescribed requirements.

4.2 First article inspection.- When a preproduction sample is required, it shall be examined for defects in table II and dimensions specified. The type I, class 2 auger shall be tested as specified in 4.4.1.

4.3 Inspection.- Sampling for inspection shall be performed in accordance with MIL-STD-105, except where otherwise indicated hereinafter.

4.3.1 Component and material inspection.- In accordance with 4.1 above, components and materials shall be inspected and tested in accordance with all the requirements of referenced specifications, drawings, and standards unless otherwise excluded, amended, modified, or qualified in this specification or applicable purchase document.

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-16T22:00Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

* 4.3.1.1 Moisture content (wood).- Determination of moisture content of wood shall be made in accordance with ASTM D2016-62. When testing is performed by the electric moisture meter, three determinations shall be made per sample unit, and the average value obtained shall conform to 3.3.1. The sample unit shall be one handle. A lot shall consist of all handles submitted for inspection at one time. The inspection level shall be S-2 with an acceptable quality level (AQL) of 2.5 defects, expressed in terms of defects per hundred units.

* 4.3.1.2 Carbon content (steel blades).- Determination of carbon content of steel blades shall be in accordance with Method No. 111.1 or 112.1 of Fed. Test Method Standard No. 151, to determine compliance with 3.3.5. The sample unit shall be as specified in the aforementioned standard, and the lot shall be all blade steel offered for inspection at one time. Results shall be recorded as pass or fail. Any failure shall be cause for rejection of the lot.

* 4.3.1.3 Hardness.- Determination of hardness shall be in accordance with ASTM E18-65 to determine compliance with 3.3.5 and 3.3.7 (when applicable). A minimum of three determinations, at least 4 inches apart on each blade, shall be made when examining for compliance with 3.3.5. All values shall be within the range specified. One determination shall be required for the spring when examining for compliance with 3.3.7. The sample size shall be the number of blades or springs (when applicable) required for the assembly of one auger. The lot shall be all blades or springs (if applicable) submitted for inspection at one time. The results shall be reported as either pass or fail.. Any failure shall be cause for rejection of the lot.

4.3.2 End item inspection.- The lot shall be all augers of each type, class and size offered for inspection at one time. The sample unit shall be one completely fabricated auger.

4.3.2.1 Visual examination.- The complete auger shall be examined for defects in table II. The inspection level shall be level II, with an AQL of 2.5 for major defects, and 6.5 for total defects, expressed in terms of defects per hundred units.

TABLE II.- Classification of defects

Examine	Defect	Classification Major	Minor
Finish	Not painted, or areas where paint is missing		X
	Painted surfaces contain blisters or embedded foreign matter		X
	Evidence of corrosion		X

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-16T22:00Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

TABLE II.- Classification of defects (cont'd)

Examine	Defect	Classification Major	Minor
Design, construction and workmanship	Operating component inoperative, or abnormal force required to operate it	X	
	Omission of a component part	X	
Forgings	Evidence of scale, inclosures, cold shuts, or mismatching	X	
Wood handle	Evidence of splinters or knots	X	
Fastening devices	Insecure, in that tightness or adjustment is not positive	X	
	Burrs and sharp edges not removed		X
Identification marking	Missing, incomplete, or illegible		X

4.3.2.2 Dimensional examination.- Examination shall be made of the augers for compliance with dimensions specified. Any noncompliance with specified requirements shall constitute a defect. The inspection level shall be S-2 with an AQL of 1.5, expressed in defects per hundred units.

4.3.2.3 End item testing.- When a preproduction sample is not required for the type I, class 2 auger, the first production item shall be tested in accordance with 4.4.1.

4.3.3 Examination of preparation for delivery.- Examination shall be made to determine compliance with preservation, packaging, packing and marking requirements in accordance with MIL-H-15424.

4.4 Test.-

4.4.1 Depth capacity (type I, class 2).- The type I, class 2 auger shall be manually operated in stable earth to a nominal depth of 8 feet, 3 inches, to determine compliance with 3.4.1.2. This test shall be performed at the 14 inch setting of the auger bit.

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-16T22:00Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

5. PREPARATION FOR DELIVERY

5.1 Levels A, B, or C.- Augers shall be preserved, packaged, packed and marked for each level of protection in accordance with the applicable requirements of MIL-H-15424 (see 6.2).

6. NOTES

6.1 Intended use.- Posthole hand augers are for use in producing holes in the earth, primarily for the insertion of posts (fence or other).

* 6.2 Ordering data.- Procurement documents should specify the following:

(a) Title, number, and date of this specification.

(b) Type, class or size required (see 1.2).

(c) First article.- When a preproduction sample is required (see 3.1).

(d) When extensions are required for size 3 and 4 (see 3.4.2.1).

(e) Selection of applicable levels of preservation and packaging and packing (see 5.1).

6.3 The margins of this specification have been marked with an asterisk (*) to indicate where changes (additions, modifications, corrections, deletions) from the previous issue were made. This was done as a convenience only and the Government assumes no liability whatsoever for any inaccuracies in these notations. Bidders and suppliers are cautioned to evaluate the requirements of this document based on the entire content irrespective of the marginal notations and relationship to the last previous issue.

Custodians:

Army - GL
Navy - YD
Air Force - 84

Preparing activity:

Army - GL

Project No. 5120-0640

Review activities:

Navy - YD
Air Force - 84, 85

User activities:

Army - ME, CE
Navy - MC

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-16T22:00Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

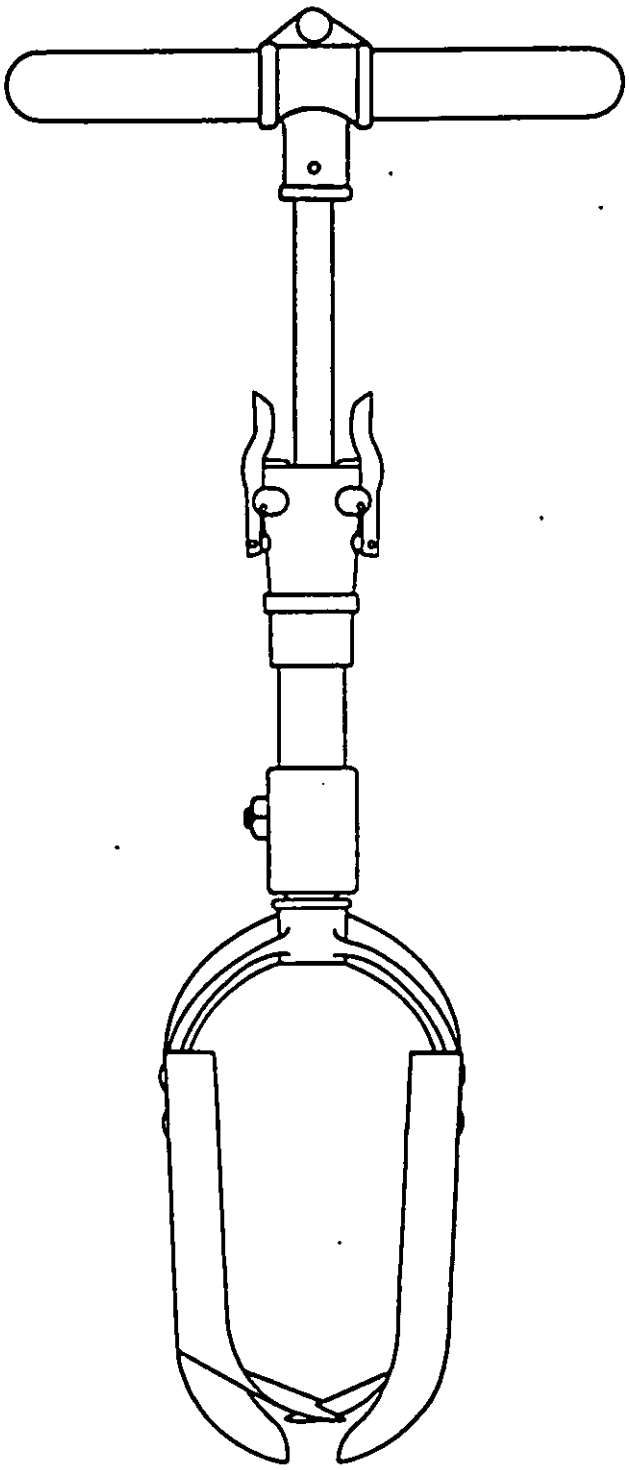


FIGURE 1.--Type I, class 1, telescoping stem and nonadjustable bit.

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-16T22:00Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

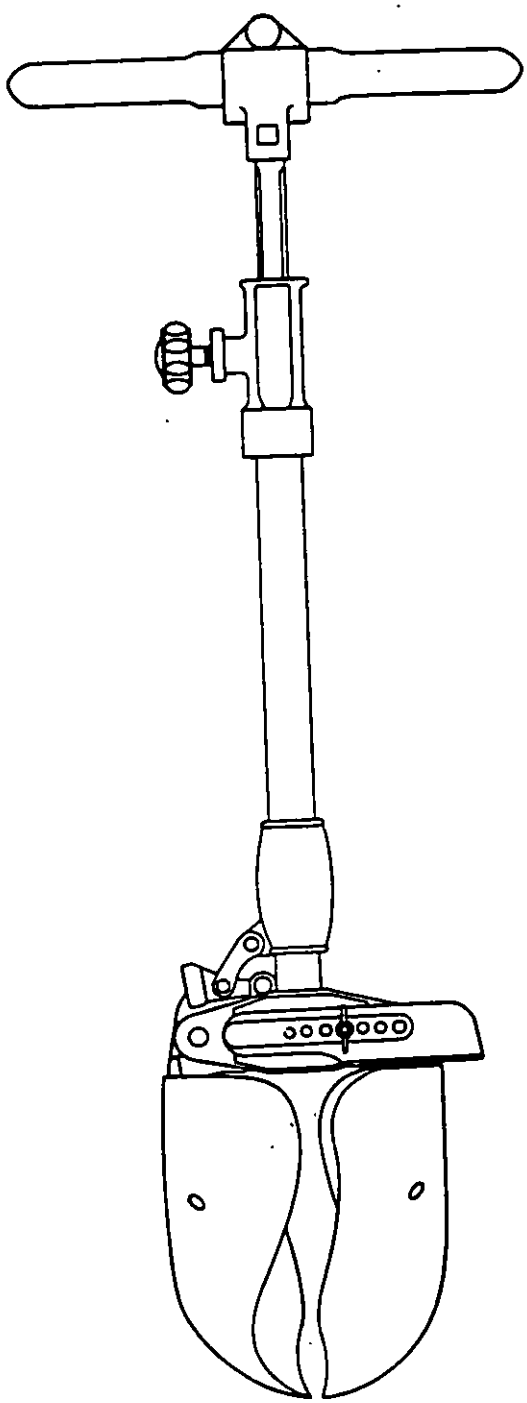


FIGURE 2.--Type I, class 2, telescoping stem and adjustable bit.

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-16T22:00Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

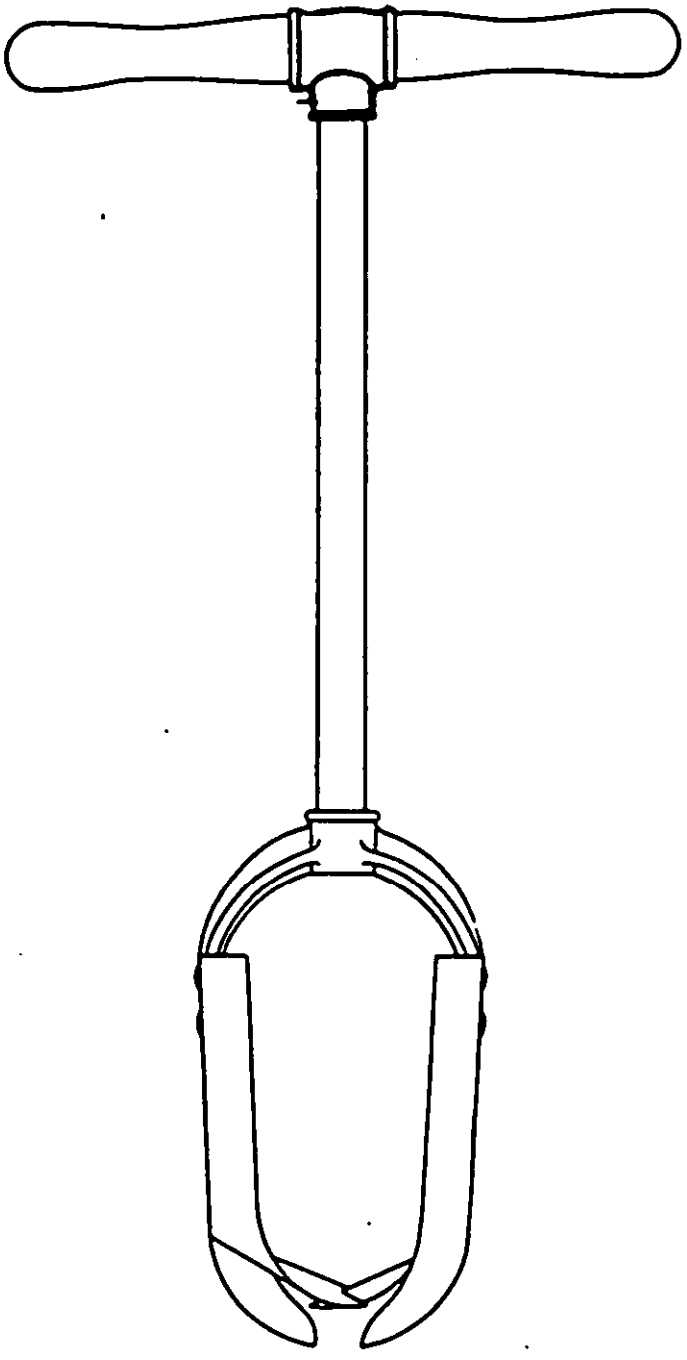


FIGURE 3.--Type II, nontelescoping stem and nonadjustable bit.

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-16T22:00Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

(TO DETACH THIS FORM, CUT ALONG THIS LINE.)

STANDARDIZATION DOCUMENT IMPROVEMENT PROPOSAL

(See Instructions – Reverse Side)

1. DOCUMENT NUMBER	2. DOCUMENT TITLE

3a. NAME OF SUBMITTING ORGANIZATION	4. TYPE OF ORGANIZATION *(Mark one)*
	☐ VENDOR ☐ USER ☐ MANUFACTURER ☐ OTHER *(Specify)*:
b. ADDRESS *(Street, City, State, ZIP Code)*	

5. PROBLEM AREAS

a. Paragraph Number and Wording:

b. Recommended Wording:

c. Reason/Rationale for Recommendation:

6. REMARKS

7a. NAME OF SUBMITTER *(Last, First, MI)* – Optional	b. WORK TELEPHONE NUMBER *(Include Area Code)* – Optional
c. MAILING ADDRESS *(Street, City, State, ZIP Code)* – Optional	8. DATE OF SUBMISSION *(YYMMDD)*

DD FORM 82 MAR 1426

PREVIOUS EDITION IS OBSOLETE.

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-16T22:00Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.